Bouquets

By Diane Wakoski

INTRODUCTION

The bystander is a modern archetype, from the Holocaust to the genocide in Rwanda to the current environmental crisis," says Charles Garfield, a clinical professor of psychology at the University of California, San Francisco. Why do some people respond to the obvious needs of others while some people turn away? Diane Wakoski examines this same phenomenon in her poem Bouquets.

Bouquets

of blood/

on the street. I know what it is, saw the man fall

(from his bicycle when his child stuck his shoe in the

spokes), saw his neighbor,

the lady who wanted to help,

bring out the roll of paper towels, thinking

to wipe up the blood from the asphalt

after the ambulance left/ but giving up her purpose

knowing she meant to wipe away memory, perhaps.

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I saw the ambulance leave, carrying him

with the flesh and bone gone from his nose,

the blood covering one eye as if

in some child's coloring book, a 3-year old had scribbled

red over a raccoon's face,

and I sat in a foreign household and watched a neatly

clad housewife bring out her roll of paper towels,

thinking to wipe up the blood off the street.

What restrained her?

I wonder.

Knowing there was so much there perhaps?

A pool so big,

the parodying of all those tv ads-"It's absorbent!"

Suburban Housewife, tell all of our listeners now just

how absorbent it *is!*"

"You wiped up a whole pool of blood spilled on the

street!"

"Now that is something, isn't it!"

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all you listeners out there,
and the exclamation points follow everything, remember
you can wipe anything away
with paper towels.
But what impressed me,
the voyeur,
the foreign visitor to this American suburb,
was that this housewife walked out, with her roll of
paper towels, and then she silently,
almost. stealthily, put them behind her back,
-ashamed, I wonder
and walked back into her house
without using them.
The pool of blood too big?
No, not for the absorbent towels.
Perhaps some sense of history
that you cannot wipe a man's blood from the pavement
when his child has thrown him there.
The bouquet

of blood

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blackens,
wears itself into the street, the stain a reminder
of a simple deadly accident.

Of life.
I remember the simple dignity
of the neighbor,
the housewife who wanted to help,
bringing out her roll of absorbent paper towels
and then not touching the pool of blood,
refraining from wiping up a man's blood as if it were
some sticky mess
her kids dropped on the floor.

Daily life dulls us.
Going to the office,
cleaning up the messes of others,
and yet some sensitivity was left to this woman.
She understood, looking at the pool of blood scraped out
of the man

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her neighbor's face, as if he had been strip-mined by

some exploiting industrialist,

she knew that she could not just wipe his blood from the

street with her paper towels.

She understood history,

memory,

record.

And I will not forget her,

a common housewife,

who rose above her nature.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Diane Wakoski
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